HOUSE OF HORRORS

A Light Jaunt Through Terror

Introduction: Within the city of Waterdeep lies the House of the Ten Fools. Legends say that a troupe of bards came upon a dark dungeon. Only one returned, forever scarred. The remaining survivor became a recluse, never to be heard from again. Until a simple invitation arrives at the character's doorsteps…

A Four-hour adventure for 1th-5th level characters

by AUTHOR NAME



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INTRODUCTION

Welcome to *House of Horrors.* I will be your humble and humorous host. Who am I? A fool has many names, tonight mine shall be Fineas Floop.

This tale of terror takes place within the city of **Waterdeep**, a bustling metropolis of adventure and daring do. Whether tonight's guests are denizens of the city or merely passersby, we shall simply not care.

I have designed my tricks and traps and treasures for…ohhh… lets say **three to five 1st-4th level characters**. It is optimized for four characters of level two. There are nine rooms to my home with several corridors of fun and delight.

Before You Play

Before you start play, consider the following:

- Read through the adventure, taking notes of anything you'd like to highlight or remind yourself of while running the adventure, such as a way you'd like to portray an NPC or a tactic you'd like to use in a combat. Familiarize yourself with the adventure's appendices and handouts.

- Gather any resources you'd like to use to aid you in running this adventure--such as notecards, a DM screen, miniatures, and battlemaps. Battlemaps are highly recommended.

- Ask the players to provide you with relevant character information, such as name, race, class, and level; passive Wisdom (Perception), and anything specified as notable by the adventure (such as backgrounds, traits, flaws, etc.)

Playing the Dungeon Master

You have the most important role—facilitating the enjoyment of the game for the players. You provide the narrative and bring the words on these pages to life.

To facilitate this, keep in mind the following:

You're Empowered. Make decisions about how the group interacts with the adventure; adjusting or improvising is encouraged, so long as you maintain the adventure's spirit. This doesn't allow you to implement house rules or change those of the Adventurers League, however; they should be consistent in this regard.

Challenge Your Players. Gauge the experience level of your players (not the characters), try to feel out (or ask) what they like in a game, and attempt to deliver the experience they're after. Everyone should have the opportunity to shine.

Keep the Adventure Moving. When the game starts to get bogged down, feel free to provide hints and clues to your players so they can attempt to solve puzzles, engage in combat, and roleplay interactions without getting too frustrated over a lack of information. This gives players "little victories" for figuring out good choices from clues. Watch for stalling—play loses momentum when this happens. At the same time, make sure that the players don't finish too early; provide them with a full play experience.

Adjusting the Adventure

You cannot improve upon my perfection. Why would you ever try. HAhahaHAahah. No, but seriously, don't mess with my stuff.

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Still here? Fine, fine. There are a few things you can do to tweak this up and down. If your players are newer or lower in level, reduce the number of animated swords by one, and maybe make some of the traps less difficult. You do you.

Still still here? Boy if you want to make these even more challenging on the poor newbies, you're even loonier than I am. More swords. Also, at the end of the adventure dump them outside of the actual Tomb of Horrors. That'll teach'm.

Adventure Primer

You must unlearn before you can learn. Regress, before you can move forward. Question, before you can understand. Die, before you can live. – ME!

Adventure Background

My merry band traveled the land, searching both far and wide. We came upon tomb, and soon found our doom - now a little voice lives inside.

I was always obsessed with the jester in the court. They were the only ones who could mock the king and get away with it. They challenged us, our boring loops and patterns. Their wit brought to light the truths in all of us. That fascination bloomed into a thriving profession. Until we found the Tomb of Horrors.

I was the only one to survive. And, I guess only a part of me did…ANYWAY, maybe I came back with a few screws loose, but I learned something from my ordeal, Acererak was a chump. First, he designed his tomb for veteran adventurers – only a few got to play. Second, it was soooo long that it took forever to get to the punchline. Third, while it hinted at the poetic comedy in tragedy, it was far from a masterpiece. It lacked the harmony, regression, and recursion of a true master.

Buckle your seatbelts boys, girls, and beholders. Tonight, for your delving delights I give you poetry.

Adventure Overview

The House of Horrors is broken down into nine rooms and several corridors. Each room is designed to be both regressive and progressive, on many layers and arcs:

- Enter with preconceptions.
- Destroy preconceptions.
- Question reality.
- Dispair.
- Embrace the journey.
- Exit reborn.

You see, this adventure is not built to *kill* the party. This is not a hack-and-slash dungeon delve. It's built to be psychological. I built my little house so that the group would not leave the way they came in. This is an experience.

There is a map for you at the end. You are welcome.

Adventure Hooks

I like stationary. Little notes and simple spells of sending. I like little adventurers to move their little feeties through my house, and I invite any I learn of in Waterdeep to my abode. A simple letter arrives, poofed into their existence before their very eyes (Hopefully with comedic or inconvenient timing)!

Grand Treasure Awaits,
To those that test their fates,
At the house on Ten Jester Road.

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And out fall the appropriate number of admissions tickets. A second letter reads the rules.

1. You cannot advance to a new room until all your group is in.
2. Everything is magical, good luck detecting.
3. Don't trust the talking statues.

There are no talking statues by the way. In case you go looking for them on the map or in the notes.

If the party asks around about me or the house. Or they talk to their gods or something or whatever (jeesh).

- A troupe of Bards came across a skull-shaped dungeon.
- Only one emerged. Wealthy, but…mentally not right…
- They say the house is haunted. Kids are not allowed to go by there.
- They say the remaining bard, Fineas Floop, is a human, and has built some sort of horrifying fun house.
- Adventurers who come out (for not all do), refuse to talk about their experience under any circumstance.

House of Horrors

Read Aloud: A normal looking house sits upon a bare lawn. Two floors, maybe 100 square feet. Simple. Victorian. Blue paint and wide windows. No ominous signs appear to mar the exterior. Save for one – a red skull for a knocker. The gate stands open. Welcoming. Inviting.

As the group approaches the porch, they can read on a DC 5 Perception check, "Everybody in, the show is about to begin."

The door, and house, on touch, seem to thrum and vibrate with a warding magic. The house itself is a magic item and cannot be broken, damaged, or dispelled by characters of this low a level.

Room One: The Chest

You enter into a…fairly quant chamber. A chair, a desk, a fancy rug fills the rooms with decorative red skulls. A simple wardrobe hangs ajar, tattered clothes lay inside.

But what catches your eye is immediate. An ornately gold and silver chest lays in the center of the room. It sits alone, no functional reason for being there.

A door sits at the end of the room.

Any attempt to detect magic reveals that everything within the house is arcane and magical. So much so that the interference is overwhelming to the relatively newer arcane caster. *Detect Magic* spells lead to one point of psychic damage from the mental overload and no discernable results.

The wardrobe and desk contain nothing of value, save two sheets of paper suitable for arcane inscription.

A DC 10 Perception check reveals faint trickles of blood around the chest. If players roll a DC 12 or higher, they also notice a still and partially decomposed hand sitting within the box.

On attempting to leave the room without opening the box, or attacking the box, the party is accosted by a **mimic.** Not the box however, the carpet springs to life and attempts to grapple anyone currently treading upon it in a surprise round by activating its adhesive ability and attacking.

Within the box, lies a *Dark Shard Amulet* with the ability to capture and store one mimic instead of its usual Warlock cantrip ability. A player need only expend one spell slot into it to capture or release a mimic.

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At the bottom of the chest reads the lines, "You must move forward, to move back. Linger too long and set off attack."

The door to the next room opens.

Any adventurers who linger in room with an open door suffer 1d4 for each round after the second in which they remain in the room that has been solved. The house has been built to not allow rest and reflection. Corridors are immune to this effect.

Four Corridors

A narrow hallway with a door at the end of it.

Adventurers with the Keen Mind feat or who roll a DC 12 Perception check notice that this house is not the same dimensions outside as inside.

These four corridors are built to be treacherous traps. Players are on a timer but also need to travel carefully. The first door opens with great ease, too easy in fact. The opener must succeed on a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or fall into a 10 foot hole (1d6 damage). On success, the hole is clearly visible. A DC 15 Perception check will reveal a red skull on the ceiling above the pit.

The third corridor's door also opens quickly, but no immediate fall takes place. Another DC 12 Dexterity saving throw occurs on stepping onto the floor, which immediately gives way. Another ten foot fall. A DC 15 Perception check will reveal a red skull on the ceiling above the false stone.

The final corridor's door is a normal door. The false floor cannot be detected by any means and is in the middle of the corridor, instead of the beginning. Only hopping over the first tile will set it off, normal movement will not. A DC 15 Dexterity saving throw can be used to avoid the trap. A red skull sits at the bottom along with 2 gems word 50gp each within its eyes.

Optional: Etched on the back of the door on a plaque, if anyone checks or succeeds on a high perception roll:

Oh, hello. This is nice, the time spent between you and I. Maybe after this we could go take a walk by the Dock Ward. No? Ok. I'm not offended. You're offended. Monster.

The mimic is tradition. A classic. Everyone knows the mimic. Well, that's no fun. They simply must learn that not everything is what it appears to be from their past experiences or foreknowledge. The unlearning begins.

Room Two: The Sword

Walls of bamboo line this room. Strong, sturdy, unyielding. Birdcall surrounds you. Ancient floors lie beneath your feet...and a red carpet just ahead. In front of you? A beautiful sword on a rack.

A DC 12 Perception check reveals the sword emanates a dark smoke. A roll below 12 causes the group to notice the carpet is rippling (there is a mild gust of air generated from beneath the carpet).

Optional: Etched on the back of the door on a plaque, if anyone checks or succeeds on a high perception roll:

I loved loved LOVED the corridors in the Tomb of Horrors. They were the moment I realized that this was more than just a dungeon, it was specifically designed to test the mind.

This is my homage, my regression to that adventure. Hopefully I've added a bit of

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depth to that goal. It's the first time I *fell* in love with a dungeon. Get it?

The carpet is the only non-magical thing in the house. The sword acts as a normal longsword if picked up, but instead deals its damage to its bearer. It is considered cursed and can be put down each time it damages its wearer on a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw. Etched into the metal of the blade is a series of vines and red skulls.

Four **Flying Swords** materialize and attack the player who removed the sword from the rack.

The door in the back of the room opens when tried.

Corridor: Interlude

Optional: Etched on the back of the door on a plaque, if anyone checks or succeeds on a high perception roll:

We do love our complexities, don't we? Having been indoctrinated by the first room that the solution is to interact with the items, and that the carpet may be evil, hopefully this will give our little crew some pause. If not? Good on them.

The key lesson of this story, is simple, do not trust what you know. This world is glorious, beautiful, and wild.

Room Three: Turntable

A throne sits atop an elevated platform in the middle of the room. It is red, ornate, ostentatious, and has fine black cherry wood arms.

At the bottom of the platform are strange symbols and two pegs.

Etched on the back of the door on a plaque, if anyone checks or succeeds on a high perception roll:

You didn't really think I'd put in more corridor & pits do you? That was sooooo last room. I wouldn't do that to you. Pits are expensive to dig you know.

A DC10 Perception check reveals three things. The pegs can rotate the throne. The symbols: a goblin, a dragon, and a beholder, match symbols on the side walls of the room. And the throne sits atop a pressure plate.

If rotated properly, and the throne is sat upon, a red orb containing a skull rises from the floor.

If the throne is sat upon in its default position, floor traps (10 foot drop) open up at random points indicated on the mat.

If the platform and throne are rotated improperly and the throne is sat upon, a blue orb rises up from the floor.

The red orb on touch teleports a user to room 4. The blue orb on touch teleports a user to room 7. Touching either orb causes all the wearer's magical items to be teleported to room 6.

Room Four: The Jester

"Ladies and gentlemen. Boys and girls. Welcome to my endgame." On a balcony above you, you see a genderless figure in a baggy, multicolored, jester suit. Rounded bells dangle from his headpiece and a manic glee lights his eyes.

"Tonight I shall be the one to play the roll of villain!" He says, covering his mount with his forearm with a gesture. "That is, after all, what you're here for. The villain, the treasure, the trope."

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On a DC12 Perception check, the player notices several holes in the floor in the middle of the room. These, ironically, are the only safe spaces. If over the next two rounds, anyone attacks the Jester, he is revealed to be a programmed illusion. Spikes emerge from all other points in the floor, dealing 1d8 damage to any player caught upon them.

After two turns, the room begins to fill with wine. As this is not water, items or spells that convey *Water Breathing* are ineffective. The room fills up rapidly as wine pours down the balcony within one minute the room is full.

```
To seek adventure is beauty. But betimes
also futility. For it's so easy, so
simple, to have ones life snuffed out. I
almost lost mine…twice. Once to that
damned place, and once to myself. So
please, learn from my mistake. Or.
Actually. Join me.
```

After thirty seconds, a pipe opens, rapidly expelling wine. Adventurers must make a DC15 athletics check or be sucked through the pipe to area 5. Taking 1d4 points of damage for their troubles.

After, any player may traverse down the pipe. The balcony no longer contains anything of significance and the teleportation orb ceases functioning.

Room Five: The Wine-y Bard

Wine is soaked into the ground. Players may take this time to rest. The door opens when approached.

Four More Corridors

The last corridor contains a pit trap at the last 5 feet before the door. A DC 15 Dexterity saving throw can be used to avoid the trap. At the bottom, of the 20 foot drop (2d6 of damage), a plaque reads, "One more for the road."

Room Six: Treasure

```
As you enter the room, you realize it is
an exact replica of the first room of the
house. A red carpet and treasure chest
sit in the center. The west wall contains
a chute with the word, "Exit" scribbled
in paint above it.
```

Optional: The chest contains an alchemy jug, a rope of climbing, a chime of opening, and 550gp. A plaque inside reads:

```
You did well. I'm proud of you. Thank you
for listening to an old fool's tale.
Destroy your preconceptions to grow, to
move beyond. And never stop moving. Or
you'll be stuck in a loop forever.
```

The room also contains any possessions lost to teleportation from room 3.

The chute dumps the players back to room 1. Right onto a new carpet-mimic. On a DC5 Perception check the players notice the doors are open, they can leave any time the chest now contains an additional 200 gp.

Room Seven: False Start

```
You are teleported back to the beginning
of the house. The doors are all shut.
```

A DC 17 Perception check reveals this is not the same room. In this room, the mimic is the chest. The door at the back of the room opens normally. The mimic only attack players who attempt to open or damage it.

More Corridors

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No pits lie in these corridors.

Optional: Etched on the back of the door on a plaque, if anyone checks or succeeds on a high perception roll:

```
Did I getcha? I hope I gotcha. I loved
watching magicians when I was a child.
They make you look one way and just when
you think you know what they are up to,
they completely baffle your expectations.
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Room Eight: Swords Again

```
Welcome back to the sword room…
```

This room is an exact duplicate of room two. Except when an adventurer touches the door in the back, they are transported back to room one. They are no longer hurried through with the damage pentalty.

```
You are teleported back to the beginning
of the house. The doors are all shut.
Everything is reset You no longer feel
rushed through the house by some unknown
force.
```

Room Nine: The Lever

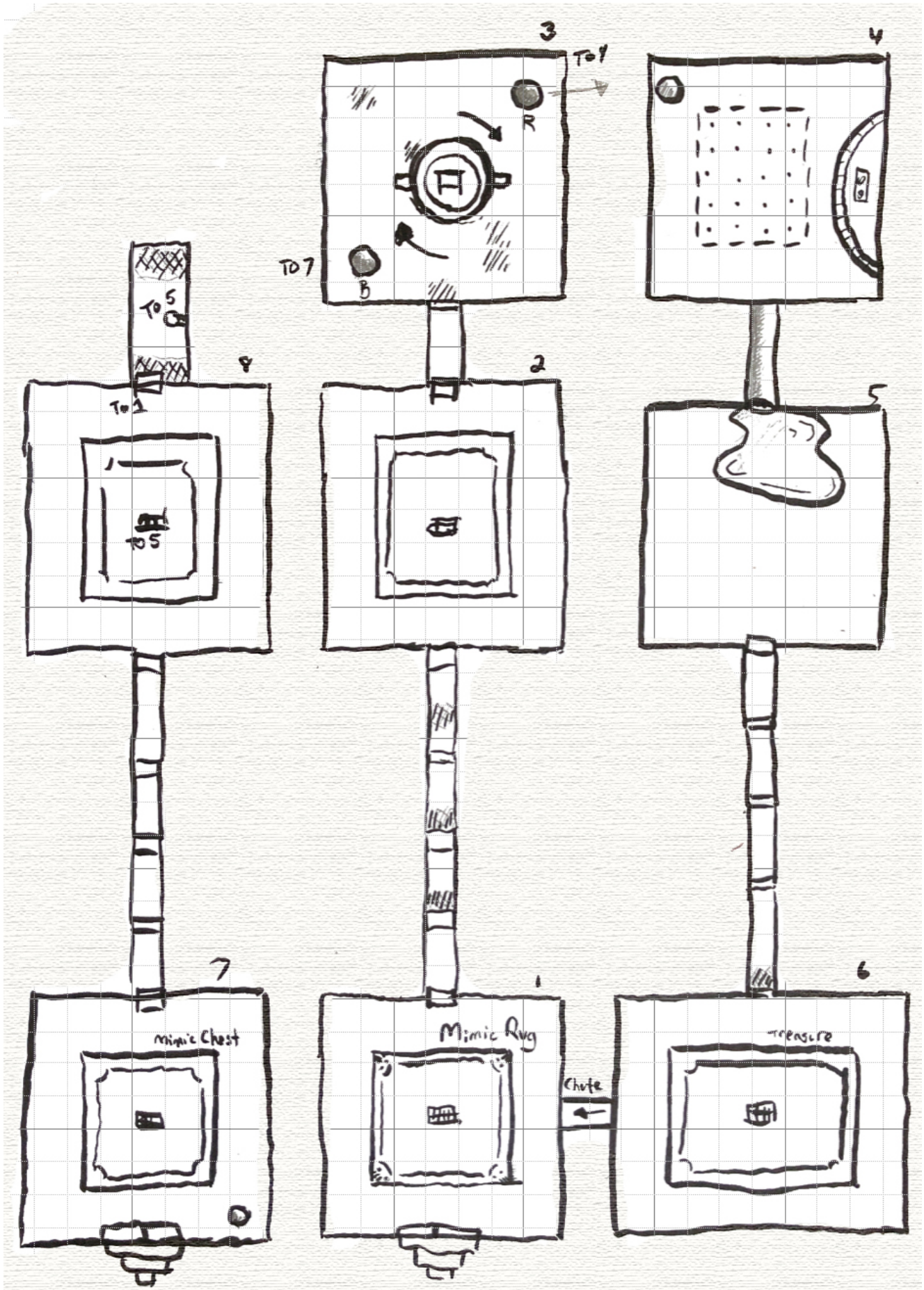
```
A lever sits in an empty chamber.
```

This room is only accessible from teleportation or if the door in room 8 was somehow destroyed. Pulling the lever opens up 20 foot pit drops on either side (see map) to room five.

Etched on the back of the door on a plaque, if anyone checks or succeeds on a high perception roll:

```
Useless room. Need to remodel this. Maybe
a theater?
```

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3
To 4
R
To 7
B
4
To 5
8
To 2
To 5
2
5
7
Mimic Chest
1
Mimic Rug
Chute
6
Treasure

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